

[Paper 2 Skills] Application Question

Learning Objectives

Students will be able to:

1. Understand what an Application Question (AQ) is and what is required to answer an AQ
2. Identify the central issue in the AQ and how to select relevant claims from the passage
3. Understand how to write a whole AQ response
4. Understand how the AQ response is graded

Section 1: What is the Application Question (AQ)?

The simplest way to understand the AQ and its requirements is to look at a sample question:

The reading passages cover a range of views people have towards complaining. How far do you agree that complaining is beneficial to society?

Support your answer with reference to:

- the ideas and opinions from **at least** one of the reading passages
- examples drawn from your own experience and that of your society. [12]

From the sample question, we know that the AQ is essentially a mini essay in the comprehension paper (Paper 2). Being a mini essay, you are required to write an introduction, body paragraphs (2 to 3), and a conclusion (just like Paper 1). The AQ is worth **12** out of 35 content marks in Paper 2, and should take around 25-30 minutes to complete.

What else do we need to do in the AQ? Is it the same as an essay?

There are two key differences between the AQ and a Paper 1 essay. As seen in the sample question, you need to:

1. **select ideas from the passage/s to respond to a question**
2. **make systematic reference to your society in your response.**

As you can see above, **the selection of claims** is a crucial first step before you even start writing the mini-essay. Let us now try to understand the thought process behind this.

Section 2: Approaching the AQ and claim selection

Before you start the AQ, you should read the question given to you and follow these **three steps**:

Step	Thinking framework <u>before</u> writing the AQ
1	Pay attention to the common theme across the passages.
2	Identify the focus of the AQ question
3	Select claims from the passage that could be used to develop a response to the focus of the AQ question in the context of your society.

Step 1: Pay attention to the common theme across the passages

- The theme helps us appreciate how all 3 passages are connected.

Sample Application Question:

The reading passages cover a range of views people have towards complaining. How far do you agree that complaining is beneficial to society? [12]

Step 2: Identify the question focus of the AQ question

- The question focus tell you exactly what your AQ response needs to address.

Sample Application Question:

The reading passages cover a range of views people have towards complaining. How far do you agree that complaining is beneficial to society?

Note that the question always starts with a “How far do you...?” This tells you that in your overall stand, and in each of your body paragraphs, you need to develop a balanced response- one that is not extreme with a fair consideration of alternative perspectives.

Samples

1. Highlight the **common theme**.
2. Draw a box around the specific question focus that you need to respond to.

GCE A Levels 2011 *(modified for 8881)*

The reading passages cover a range of observations about how valuable parks and green spaces are to cities and their inhabitants. How far do you agree with the view that parks benefit everyone in society?

Support your answer with reference to:

- the ideas and opinions from **at least** one of the reading passages
- examples drawn from your own experience and that of your society.

GCE A Levels 2013 *(modified for 8881)*

The reading passages cover a range of views on the distinctions between actions which earn ‘true fame’ and the modern day interest in the actions of celebrities without much talent. How far do you agree with the view some celebrities are unworthy of their fame?

Support your answer with reference to:

- the ideas and opinions from **at least** one of the reading passages
- examples drawn from your own experience and that of your society.

Step 3: Select relevant claims from the passage that could be used to develop a response to the focus of the AQ question in the context of your society. When selecting claims, take note of the following general requirements:

- Reference "...ideas and opinions from at least one of the reading passages".

This tells you that there is need to reference ideas from the passage that can be used to in your response. While it is explicitly stated that references to one passage alone would suffice, it is recommended that at least 2 passages are referenced to broaden the range of views that can be incorporated in the discussion.

- The claims chosen must be closely related to the theme and the question focus. You might also want to ensure that the claims you eventually use have scope for discussion (e.g. you have relevant points and examples for the claim)

Do also remember that you would need to use the claims to develop a response in the context of your society. This is stated in the general requirements as well i.e. Reference "...examples drawn from your own experience and that of your society.

[Tip!] During your first reading of the passages, make a note beside the claims that are applicable or not applicable to your society. This will help you remember your initial ideas when you are planning the essay. You should also check if your claims will allow you to answer the question focus.

How to select a relevant claim:

Claims selected generally should flow naturally into the development of a response. As such, a claim could be:

- **the point of view provided by the author/s**
- **the reasons the author/s provide to support the view**
- **the evidence that is used to substantiate the view**
- **a feature of society**
- **an observation of trends in the world**

Section 3: Writing the whole AQ

Your entire AQ response is structured like a Paper 1 Essay. This is an overview:

[Introductory Paragraph]	
1.	Relate the common theme to your society and broadly discuss its place in your society's context.
2.	Based on the above, come to an overall stand to the question focus that provides room for balance. State your balanced overall stand explicitly . <i>Do not use vague phrases such as "to a certain extent" or "to some extent".</i>
[Supporting Viewpoint Paragraph*] {1 point}	
[Supporting Viewpoint Paragraph*] {1 point}	
[Concluding Paragraph]	
1.	Give an overall critical comment of the central issue
2.	Reiterate the overall stand which was mentioned in the introductory paragraph

***IMPORTANT NOTE:** At least one of the supporting viewpoint paragraphs need to include a **balance EV (i.e. the second strategy demonstrated later)**. This ensures that your overall response is not one-sided. **An awareness of opposing views is critical as part of a balanced response.** As shown in the A-level rubric for the AQ (see section 5), a 'balanced treatment' is required for you to do well.

Section 4: Crafting an AQ Body Paragraph

There isn't a need to follow a formulaic paragraph development structure for the AQ especially since the selected claim can be used at various points within the paragraph development. Nonetheless, you could use the body paragraph structure below if you are engaging a reason provided by the author.

	Component	Details
1	Quote the author's claim	This is where you refer to the text and quote a relevant claim (please include a line reference so that we know where you extracted the claim from).
2	Explanation of author's claim (optional)	Explain the essential parts of the author's claim if it is unclear.
3	Reason	Provide the reason for your stand. Provide additional explanation if necessary.
4	Example + Explanation of Example	Provide a relevant and factual example from your society that supports your stand in this paragraph. Explain how the example supports your stand in this paragraph.
5	Evaluation	This is where you include balance or highlight the effectiveness of your argument or your example. In doing so, balance and Conceptual Understanding becomes apparent.
6	Concluding Sentence	Conclude your paragraph by reiterating your point.

To help you see how the above steps come together, please take a look at the following AQ body paragraph. We have indicated the various components of the paragraph for you:

AQ Question:

The reading passages cover a range of views people have towards complaining. How far do you agree that complaining is beneficial to society?

Support your answer with reference to:

- the ideas and opinions from **at least** one of the reading passages
- examples drawn from your own experience and that of your society

Overall Stand:

I largely agree that complaining is beneficial to my society in Singapore.

Argument/Claim that has been selected:

“Complaining alerts the world that the problem is a problem.”

Steps	Text from sample Application Question response	Explanation of steps
1. Quote the author’s claim	In passage 1, lines 98-99, the author claims that “complaining alerts the world that the problem is a problem.”	Include passage & line references for direct quotes: • <i>In passage 1, lines 98-99...</i> Refer to the author’s claim by beginning your sentence with such phrases: • ... the author claims that... • ... the author argues that... • ... the author believes that... • ... the author asserts that... • ... the author raises the point that... • ... according to the author...
2. Explanation of author’s claim (optional)	This means that complaining allows the residents in the society to voice their unhappiness and they are able to highlight the underlying issues within society.	If the quotation is self-explanatory, there is no need to do this. Otherwise, explain the author’s claim in terms of the ‘how’ or ‘why’. Do not merely paraphrase it. NOTE: Do not use more than 1 sentences to clarify what the writer means.

3. Stand + Reason	The Singapore government today is taking a deliberate move away from authoritarian governance, and taking a more pro-active stance towards hearing the feedback and complaints of the people. This often allows public complaints to alert the government of potential issues in society.	A balanced response is persuasive because it shows consideration for alternative points by anticipating doubts and objections a critical reader might have. Use measured and nuanced language that help you accurately reflect the degree or extent of your stand (as taught in your P1 skills) Examples of measured language: • ‘leads almost inexorably to...’ • ‘can often result in...’ • ‘the most likely outcome being...’ • ‘this correlates strongly with...’ • ‘can possibly result in...’ • ‘which may cause...’ • ‘for the most part...’ Examples of nuanced language: • ‘this is especially evident given [C]...’ • ‘which is most pronounced in...’ • ‘despite the fact that’ • ‘which, taken together with [F]...’ • ‘even taking into consideration [F]...’ • ‘due in large part to...’ (2) You must also provide a brief reason to support your stand based on broad trends/characteristics/features of your society. We need to know why you took that stand in the context of your society. Features you may consider: ✓ General facts (e.g. regarding population, education system, etc) ✓ Social trends (e.g. dual-income family, more people getting married late, etc) ✓ History (e.g. racial harmony is prioritised because of racial riots in the past) ✓ Geography (e.g. Singapore’s size / high population density / location / etc) ✓ Government policies (e.g. HDB ethnic quota, etc) ✓ Issues and debates on current affairs (e.g. immigration, ageing population, etc)
4. Example	The Singaporean government makes active use of various channels, both online and offline, to hear the voices of the people. For instance, constituents with grievances may choose to air them during a Member of Parliament’s (MP) meet-the-people-session, or via interactions at Community Development Councils (CDCs) and island-wide feedback dialogues. To enhance their reach, the government feedback unit Reach also reached out to citizens via e-Listening Points, in the form of online surveys	Examples Similar to Paper 1, you need to exemplify your stand and reason with concrete evidence. However, in the AQ <u>the examples must come from your society</u>. Like reasons, evidence could be in the form of social trends, government policies, history, geography issues and debates on current affairs and/or statistics from research or survey findings. However, the difference is that evidence is more specific, with specific facts, events or statistics to support the reasons. Explanation of Example

Explanation of Example	and platforms like WhatsApp, TikTok and Clubhouse. Such feedback became valuable data points for policy-makers, evident from how the Health Ministry sought to boost manpower in the healthcare sector after anonymous feedback from more than 600 healthcare workers highlighted that they were on the verge of breaking down. Such examples point towards how the act of complaining in Singapore is not simply an idle rant, but a significant way through which the citizens get their voices heard.	Similar to Paper 1, your explanation of example should elaborate on how or why your example supports your topic sentence. The explanation of example forms the crucial link between your example and the point in your topic sentence.
5. Evaluation	With all of that said, I do acknowledge that it is not always true that complaints in Singapore are helpful in highlighting truly important issues. Singaporeans, long known for being avid complainers, have also gained a reputation for complaining about the most banal and trivial issues. Gems that have been published on our national broadsheet, The Straits Times, include a call for stemming the rise of tattoos, concern over the sale of fried rice, and Singaporeans' tendency to not use verbs in the past-tense. These examples, it can be argued, illustrate how complaints in Singapore do not always highlight important issues and may sometimes be disadvantageous as it causes people to brush past such constant complaining without delving deeper into the issues. <u>Still, it has to be said that they are minor exceptions that do not undermine my original point that complaints raised help to highlight</u>	'Evaluation' involves injecting some form of assessment or value judgement in response to an issue by looking at things in terms of the larger picture. The evaluation allows you to demonstrate balance and conceptual understanding through your thorough awareness regarding the issue. Similar to Paper 1, there are three main evaluation strategies in the AQ (you do not have to use all three in one paragraph): 1) [Strengthening EV] Evaluation that involves strengthening your point by showing how convincing it is via the use of evaluative strategies. <u>Sample (using Majority-Minority EV strategy)</u> [Strengthening EV] <i>In fact, this has been a <u>growing trend</u> in Singapore, as Reach noted. More importantly, Singaporeans are complaining not just for their own sake – we also see a <u>burgeoning</u> civil society that complains and advocates on behalf of the marginalised. This is evident from how activists and non-governmental organisations like Transient Workers Count Too (TWC2) continually raised complaints on behalf of migrant workers who had to live in cramped and unsanitary conditions. It is clear from these instances that complaining has indeed helped residents in Singapore make their issues known, <u>regardless of their age or nationality</u>.</i>

	<u>pertinent social issues in a society with rising social awareness.</u>	2) [Balance EV] Evaluation that highlights some limitation in your own argument in order to achieve balance in the essay. <u>Sample as shown in column on left.</u> IMPORTANT NOTE #1. If you employ this, it is important to note that the limitation you are highlighting cannot be so strong as to undermine your Stand. #2. It is thus important that you end with a line that emphasizes your original Stand (see underlined part of the sample). Here are some signalers to indicate to the reader that you are merely recognizing a minor limitation/exception: a) <i>Still, it has to be said that these minor exceptions do not undermine my broader argument that (insert your original stand).</i> b) <i>However, these instances are merely a drop in the ocean and they do not constitute a meaningful threat to my initial point.</i> c) <i>With that said, trends in Singapore are definitely changing, and my broader argument mentioned earlier still stands in spite of these concessions.</i> 3) [Rebuttal EV] Evaluation that aims at weakening any opposing arguments in order to reassert the overall strength of your argument by: • pointing out possible flaws or fallacies in the presentation of argument and examples made by the opponents. • exposing possible limitations of the opposing argument. As mentioned in the earlier lectures, an easy rebuttal can be crafted by: ○ Demonstrating how problems are less serious than they appear. ○ Engaging in a cost-benefit analysis.
6. Concluding Sentence	In conclusion, I largely agree that complaining is beneficial to my society in Singapore.	Wrap up your AQ body paragraph by reminding the marker of your point.

Section 5: Marking Rubrics for the AQ (REE)

The Application Question is assessed using **REE**: **R**equirements, **E**xplanation, **E**valuation.

Based on your fulfilment of the four individual components, you will be placed either in Band 4, 3, 2, or 1, to be given a mark accordingly.

Band	Mark
4	10 – 12
3	7 – 9
2	4 – 6
1	1 – 3
0 marks: Nothing in the answer meets any of the criteria.	

The table below shows what you must have in your AQ in order to hit Band 4:

Assessment Component	You must show throughout the AQ:
<u>R</u>equirements [R]	Sustained focus on the requirements of the question; balanced response
<u>E</u>xplanation [EX]	Cogent answer with very good understanding of the terms and issues raised by the passages
<u>E</u>valuation [EV]	Convincing evaluation, making of judgements, and developing arguments to logical conclusions; elaboration and support through personal insight and experience, with apt illustration

In order to achieve the above, we have provided you with the **Approach** to tackle your AQ (see Sections 3 and 4). If you follow the structure and the steps well, you will definitely be able to hit all requirements and score Band 4.

Full AQ Structure

The reading passages cover a range of views on parents monitoring their children's online activities.

How far do you agree that parents should monitor their children's online activities?

Support your answer with reference to:

- the ideas and opinions from **at least** one of the reading passages
- examples drawn from your own experience and that of your society.

Intro 1(HCI): Provide gist of passages and stand + reason - Passage 1 argues .. - H/W, Passage 2 argues ... - My stand is (... should/should monitor ...) ... because ...	Intro 2: stand + SG feature + larger SG context/trend - My stand is ... (... should/should monitor ...) - Due to SG feature(s) [tip of the iceberg] - Can be further supported by larger SG context/trend [90% of the hidden iceberg]
BP1: - Cite a point from 1 of the passages + explanation of the point cited - My stand is [relevance of the point] + reason [SG features] - EG1 – national/societal level + explain - EG2 – individual/personal level + explain - Common point/insight drawn from both EGs - H/W, may be critics/challenges to your point + brief explanation + 1 EG - Rebuttal/Concession [refute the critics] + explain - Restate my stand	Remarks for BP1: 1. Requirement to use/draw ideas from at least 1 of the passages 2. Provide an assessment/answer to the given AQ 3. At least 2 EGs from larger context + personal experiences 4. Must be insightful – analyse and show the significance of your examples in how SG features/context would lead you to adopt a particular stand in the AQ 5. Must be balance – both sides and hence bring out the critics 6. Must be evaluative – a. rebuttal/concession – EV lens: Majority vs minority, old vs young, foreigners/local, past vs present b. use larger SG context ○ SG's constraint ○ SG's national/historical experiences ○ Dominant social values/norms or customs/practices/beliefs ○ Dominant political culture ○ Open to external shocks
BP2: - Cite a point from another passage + explanation of the point cited - My stand is [relevance of the point] + reason [SG features]	Remarks for BP2: 1. Requirement to use/draw ideas from at least 1 of the passages 2. Provide an assessment/answer to the given AQ

- EG1 – national/societal level + explain - EG2 – individual/personal level + explain - Common point/insight drawn from both EGs - Use larger SG context <i>If there is need for BP3, you can either follow the structure BP1 or BP2.</i>	3. At least 2 EGs from larger context + personal experiences 4. Must be insightful – analyse and show the significance of your examples in how SG features/context would lead you to adopt a particular stand in the AQ 5. Must be evaluative – a. use larger SG context - o SG's constraint - o SG's national/historical experiences - o Dominant social values/norms or customs/practices/beliefs - o Dominant political culture - o Open to external shocks
Conclusion: 1. Restate my stand 2. Due to SG features 3. Larger SG context	